Historical source

Encyclopaedia Britannica scan, source row 1422. Parse 3.5 extracted the text. Super 3.5 VL corrected it from an enlarged crop of each block. It can still contain recognition errors. Page headers, footers, and page numbers are removed.

Untitled continuation (E0119)

Continues an entry from an earlier page.

highly worthy of engaging the attention of the young gentleman. Dancing, fencing, running, horsemanship, the management of the musket, and the motions of military discipline, are none of them unworthy of occupying his time, at proper seasons. It is unnecessary to point out the advantages which he may derive from dancing; these seem to be pretty generally understood. Perhaps our men of fortune would be ashamed to make use of their legs for running; but occasions may occur, on which even this humble accomplishment may be useful. Though we wish not to see the young man of fortune become a jockey; yet to be able to make a graceful appearance on horseback, and to manage his horse with dexterity, will not be unworthy of his station and character. If times of public danger should arise, and the state should call for the services of her subjects against any hostile attack, they whose rank and fortune place them in the most eminent stations will be first expected to hand forth; but if unacquainted with those exercises which are connected with the military art, what a pitiful figure must they make in the camp, or on the field of battle?

Lav.

73 History and morals.

Philosophy-

Natural philosophy, as being both highly useful and entertaining, is well worthy of the attention of all who can afford to appropriate any part of their time to scientific pursuits; to the man of fortune, a taste for natural philosophy might often procure the most delightful entertainment. To trace the wonders of the planetary systems, to mark the progress of vegetation, to examine all the properties of that fine element which we breathe, to trace the laws by which all the different elements are confined to their proper functions, and above all to apply the principles of natural philosophy in the cultivation of the ground, are amusements which might agreeably and innocently occupy many of the leisure hours of the man who enjoys a plentiful and independent fortune.

Neither do we suppose civil history and the principles of morals to be overlooked. Without being acquainted with these, how could any just or accurate knowledge of the laws and political constitution of his country be acquired by the young gentleman? History exposes to our observation the fortune and the actions of other human beings, and thus supplies in some measure the place of experience; it teaches prudence, and affords exercise to the moral sense. When history condescends to take notice of individuals, they are almost always such as have been eminent for virtue, for abilities, or for the rank which they held in life; to the rich and great it ought to speak with peculiar efficacy, and they ought to be carefully invited to listen to its voice.

Such then is the manner in which we wish the education of young men of rank and fortune to be conducted, in order that they may be prepared for enjoying their opulence and honours with becoming dignity. Let them be early inured to habits of vigorous

industry and persevering firmness, by passing through a regular course of classical learning in a free school; let them play and converse with their equals, and not be permitted to form high ideas of their own importance, nor to domineer over servants or inferiors: Let them be carefully instructed in the principles of morality and religion: Let them be taught the many exercises: Let them be carefully informed of the nature of the political constitution of their country, and of the extent of the civil and political rights which it secures to them and their fellow-citizens: Let them be called to trace the annals of mankind through the records of history; to mark the appearances and operations of nature, and to amuse themselves by purifying these to their general causes. We say nothing of causing the young man of fortune to learn some mechanical art: We think skill in a mechanical art might now and then afford him an innocent and pleasing amusement; but we do not consider it as absolutely necessary, and therefore do not insist on his acquiring it. With those accomplishments we hope he might become an useful member of society, might adorn the rank and fortune to which he is born, and might find wealth and high station a blessing, not a curse. It is peculiarly unfortunate for our age and country, that people of rank and fortune are not so studious that their children acquire these as the more superficial accomplishments.

VII (E0120)

VII. On the Education of People designed for a Mercantile Employment, and for the humbler Occupations in Life not particularly connected with Literature.

Were modern literature in a less flourishing state; were the English and French languages adorned with sewer eminent poetical, historical, and philosophical compositions; we might perhaps insist on it as necessary to give the boy, who is designed for a mercantile employment, a classical education. At present this does not appear absolutely necessary; yet we do not presume to forbid it as improper. Even the merchant will scarce find reason to repent his having been introduced to the acquaintance of Plato and Cicero. But still, if the circumstances of the parent, or any other just reason, should render it inconvenient to send the young man who is intended for trade to a free school to study the ancient languages, means may be easily adopted to make up for his loss. Confine him not to writing and accounts alone. These, though particularly useful to the merchant, have no great power to restrain the force of evil passions, or to inspire the mind with generous and virtuous sentiments. Though you burden him not with Latin and Greek, yet strive to inspire him with a taste for useful knowledge and for elegant literature. Some of the purest and most elegant of our poets, the excellent periodical works which have appeared in our language, such as the Spectator, the Adventurer, the Mirror, and the compositions of our British historians, together with some of the best translations of the classics which we possess; these you may with great propriety put into his hands. They will teach him how to think and reason justly, and to express himself in conversation or in writing with correctness and elegance; they will refine and polish his mind, and raise him above low and gross pleasures. And as no man, who has any occasion to speak or write, ought to be entirely ignorant of the principles of grammar, you will

Source record

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